

Hosting Costs & Go-Live Requirements

Double Helix Pharma UK Ltd — running the site on DigitalOcean, with Microsoft 365 email

Document	Hosting Costs & Go-Live Requirements
Version	2.0 (DigitalOcean + Microsoft 365 edition)
Date	9 June 2026
Target host	DigitalOcean Droplet (self-managed Linux server)
Email	Microsoft 365 — 4 mailboxes (form notifies one)
Application	Next.js (App Router) — built & running

All figures are indicative, in GBP and exclusive of VAT (reclaimable for a VAT-registered company), as at June 2026. US-dollar services (DigitalOcean) are converted at approximately \$1 = £0.79. Microsoft and DigitalOcean list prices may change — Microsoft has a further UK increase scheduled for July 2026.

1. At a glance

Your website and its backend are **already built**. This document covers the cost and the steps to run it on a **DigitalOcean Droplet** (a Linux server you own and control) with **Microsoft 365** providing four staff mailboxes and sending the enquiry alerts. The database runs as a file **on the server's own disk**, so no separate database service is needed.

Scenario	What it gives you	Cost / month (ex VAT)
Lean	1GB server + Microsoft 365 Business Basic x4 + domain.	~ £29
Recommended	2GB server + automatic backups + M365 Basic x4 + domain.	~ £35
Fuller	As recommended, but M365 Business Standard (desktop Office) x4.	~ £58

BOTTOM LINE The website itself is cheap to host (a £5–£10 / month server). The bulk of the cost is the **four Microsoft 365 mailboxes** — that is real staff email you own, roughly £23 / month on the Basic plan, not a website expense as such.

Indicative monthly running cost (ex VAT)



The 4 Microsoft 365 mailboxes are the largest part of the cost — the server itself is cheap.

Figure 1 — Indicative monthly running cost by scenario (excludes VAT; domain amortised).

2. Your chosen setup (the stack)

Five parts. You own and run the server (the DigitalOcean Droplet); everything the app needs to store lives on that same server, which keeps the architecture simple and avoids a separate database bill.

Part	What it does	Plan	Cost	Status
DigitalOcean Droplet	A Linux server that runs the whole app (site + backend).	2GB Droplet	~ £9.50/mo	To set up
SQLite (on the disk)	The database — stores enquiries and editable content.	On-server file	£0	Ready in code
Microsoft 365	Four staff mailboxes; the form emails enquiries to one.	Business Basic x4	~ £23/mo	To set up
Cloudflare Turnstile	CAPTCHA — blocks spam / bot form submissions.	Free	£0	Action needed
Domain registrar	Your public web address (e.g. a .co.uk).	Annual	~ £10/yr	To purchase

IMPORTANT Because the database is a single file on one server, **backups are essential** — a server can fail. The recommended plan includes DigitalOcean's automatic backups (+20%); we also add a nightly database snapshot. Without backups, a server loss would lose your enquiries.

3. Monthly cost breakdown

The same site under three budget levels. The only real differences are the server size, whether automatic backups are on, and which Microsoft 365 plan the four mailboxes use.

Line item	Lean	Recommended	Fuller
Server — DigitalOcean Droplet	£4.75 (1GB)	£9.50 (2GB)	£9.50 (2GB)
Automatic server backups (+20%)	—	£1.90	£1.90
Database — SQLite on the server	£0	£0	£0
Email — Microsoft 365 x4 mailboxes	£23.00 (Basic)	£23.00 (Basic)	£46.20 (Standard)
CAPTCHA — Cloudflare Turnstile	£0	£0	£0
Domain name (amortised)	£0.83	£0.83	£0.83
TOTAL / month (ex VAT)	~ £29	~ £35	~ £58
TOTAL / year (ex VAT)	~ £345	~ £420	~ £700

Microsoft 365: Business Basic £5.75 and Business Standard £11.55 per user / month (ex VAT), x4 mailboxes. DigitalOcean billed in USD (~\$12 = £9.50 for the 2GB Droplet). VAT is added on top but is normally reclaimable for a VAT-registered company.

4. One-time & optional costs

- **Domain name (recommended, ~£8–£12 / year).** The only purchase needed to launch on your own address. Buy from Cloudflare Registrar, Namecheap or GoDaddy; renews yearly.
- **Initial server setup (one-time).** Installing the runtime, web server, HTTPS and first deploy on the Droplet. We provide a setup script and run it with you — no software licence cost.
- **HTTPS / SSL certificate (£0).** Free and automatic via Let's Encrypt (renews itself).
- **Microsoft 365 — email-only alternative.** If the four users only need email (no Teams/Office), Exchange Online Plan 1 is cheaper (about £3.30 / user / month, ex VAT) — ask your Microsoft reseller.
- **CAPTCHA keys (£0).** Cloudflare Turnstile is free; you just create a widget to obtain the keys.

5. Everything needed to make the app work

Requirement	What it is for	Cost	Status
DigitalOcean account + Droplet	The server that runs the site.	~ £9.50/mo	To set up
Server stack (Node 20, Nginx, SSL)	Serves the app securely over HTTPS.	£0	To configure
Database (SQLite on disk)	Stores enquiries + content.	£0	Ready in code
Automatic backups	Protects the on-server database.	~ £1.90/mo	Recommended
Microsoft 365 (4 mailboxes)	Staff email + sending enquiry alerts.	~ £23/mo	To set up
Email app registration (Graph)	Lets the app send mail through M365.	£0	To configure
Bot protection (Turnstile keys)	Stops spam on the contact form.	£0	Action needed
Domain name	Your public web address.	~ £10/yr	To purchase
Canonical URL setting	Correct SEO / sitemap once live.	£0	After domain

WHO DOES WHAT Most items are configuration we carry out for you. The things only **you** can do are: open a DigitalOcean account, buy the domain, and in Microsoft 365 create the 4 mailboxes plus one “app registration” so the website is allowed to send mail. Details in section 7.

6. Migration plan — Vercel to DigitalOcean

A staged move with no downtime: the site keeps running on its current address until the new server is tested and the domain is switched over at the end.

- 1 Provision a DigitalOcean Droplet (Ubuntu 24.04 LTS, 2GB) and secure it (firewall, non-root user, SSH keys).
- 2 Install the runtime: Node.js 20, Nginx as a reverse proxy, and a process manager to keep the app running and restart it on reboot.
- 3 Deploy the app from GitHub and run an optimised production build (Next.js “standalone” output) on the server.
- 4 Point the database at a file on the server's persistent disk and seed the live content; switch email from Resend to Microsoft 365 (already coded — just supply the keys).
- 5 Add a free Let's Encrypt HTTPS certificate (auto-renewing).
- 6 Set all environment variables on the server (database path, security secret, admin login, Microsoft 365 + Turnstile keys, public site URL).
- 7 Turn on automatic backups and a nightly database snapshot.
- 8 Test everything on the server's temporary address, then repoint the domain's DNS to the Droplet and retire the Vercel deployment.

HOW WE RUN IT We make the code and configuration changes (standalone build, Microsoft 365 email, server scripts). We can run the server steps with you over SSH, or hand you a copy-paste runbook — your choice.

7. What you need to provide

To carry out the move we will need the following from you. None of it is difficult; we guide each step.

Item	Why it is needed	Where to get it
DigitalOcean account	To create and pay for the server.	digitalocean.com — sign up (card required).
Domain name	Your public web address.	Any registrar; tell us the exact name.
Microsoft 365 admin access	To create the 4 mailboxes.	Microsoft 365 admin centre.
M365 app registration details	Lets the website send mail via M365.	We guide it in Azure / Entra: gives a Tenant ID, Client ID and a secret.
The send-from + notify addresses	Which mailbox sends, which receives enquiries.	You choose, e.g. send from contact@, notify enquiries@.
Cloudflare Turnstile keys	Real spam protection.	dash.cloudflare.com — free Turnstile widget.
Server access (SSH)	So we can set the server up.	Created with the Droplet; or do the steps with us.

EMAIL METHOD On sending mail: the website will send through Microsoft 365 using the secure modern method (Microsoft Graph, an “app registration”). This avoids older password-based email that Microsoft is retiring. It is well within Microsoft 365's limits for a contact form's low volume.

8. Recommendation & budget

- **Server:** a 2GB DigitalOcean Droplet with automatic backups (~£11.40 / month) — comfortable headroom for Next.js and protected against server loss.
- **Email:** Microsoft 365 Business Basic for the four mailboxes (~£23 / month) unless the team needs the desktop Office apps, in which case Business Standard.
- **Database:** keep it simple — SQLite on the server's disk (£0), with the nightly backup we set up.
- **To launch:** buy a domain and create the four mailboxes + the app registration; we do the rest.

Budget option	Per month (ex VAT)	Per year (ex VAT)
Lean (1GB, M365 Basic x4)	~ £29	~ £345
Recommended (2GB + backups, M365 Basic x4)	~ £35	~ £420
Fuller (2GB + backups, M365 Standard x4)	~ £58	~ £700

In short: **the app is built and ready to move.** Hosting it on your own DigitalOcean server is inexpensive; the main ongoing cost is the four Microsoft 365 mailboxes — which give you proper, owned company email. Budget around **£35 / month** (ex VAT) for the recommended setup, plus a domain.

— End of summary —